

The Gift of the Magi

O. Henry · 1905

First published: New York Sunday World, Dec 1905

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Four_Million/The_Gift_of_the_Magi (revision 13321101), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about sacrificial love?
- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about wealth and poverty?
- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about irony of giving?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Gift of the Magi	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*sacrificial love* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Gift of the Magi

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a cheap furnished flat in New York at the start of the twentieth century, when millions of clerks and shop workers lived on a few dollars a week. The title refers to the Magi of the Gospel of Matthew, who brought gifts to the infant Jesus, the origin of Christmas gift-giving.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the New York Sunday World on 10 December 1905; collected in The Four Million (1906), whose title answers the claim that only "four hundred" people in New York society mattered.

Then: Immediately popular; it helped make O. Henry the best-known story writer in America.

Now: One of the most adapted and anthologized Christmas stories, the classic example of situational irony and the "twist ending."

Overview (spoiler-free)

Della has one dollar and eighty-seven cents to buy her husband Jim a Christmas present. Each of them owns one treasure: her long hair and his gold watch.

Main themes

- sacrificial love.
- poverty and dignity.
- the meaning of gifts.

Why it matters

Students learn how irony shapes meaning and think about what makes a gift valuable.

Spoilers · teacher only

Della sells her hair to buy Jim a chain for his watch; Jim sells his watch to buy her combs for her hair. The narrator calls them the wisest of givers.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Gift of the Magi: What is the best gift you've given or received? Why did it matter?
Prompt: Before we open The Gift of the Magi: What is the best gift you've given or received? Why did it matter?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

situational irony; twist ending; narrator's voice; allusion; Magi.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. Set in a cheap furnished flat in New York at the start of the twentieth century, when millions of clerks and shop workers lived on a few dollars a week. The title refers to the Magi of the Gospel of Matthew, who brought gifts to the infant Jesus, the origin of Christmas gift-giving. Publication and reception. First published in the New York Sunday World on 10 December 1905; collected in The Four Million (1906), whose title answers the claim that only "four hundred" people in New York society mattered. Then: Immediately popular; it helped make O. Henry the best-known story writer in America. Now: One of the most adapted and anthologized Christmas stories, the classic example of situational irony and the "twist ending."

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1). The opening.

> *ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: "ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1). The opening.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Della has one dollar and eighty-seven cents to buy her husband Jim a Christmas present. Each of them owns one treasure: her long hair and his gold watch. Themes to track: sacrificial love.: poverty and dignity.: the meaning of gifts.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Gift of the Magi: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Gift of the Magi still matter? Students learn how irony shapes meaning and think about what makes a gift valuable.
Anchor question: Why might The Gift of the Magi still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students learn how irony shapes meaning and think about what makes a gift valuable.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does the narrator call Della and Jim "the wisest"? Answer: Their gifts are useless, but each sacrificed their greatest treasure for the other; the love is the true gift.
Exit ticket: Why does the narrator call Della and Jim "the wisest"?
Answer: Their gifts are useless, but each sacrificed their greatest treasure for the other; the love is the true gift.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Gift of the Magi.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin), biography and works (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The exact first-publication date (10 December 1905) is the one commonly given; confirm against the New York World archive if precision matters.

Lesson 2: The Gift of the Magi

Focus: love measured by sacrifice

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her hair. The narrator calls the two foolish children but declares them the wisest of givers: they are the magi.

Background: O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks.

Significance: A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to sacrificial love because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to sacrificial love because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: ransacking — searching a place thoroughly, often roughly; cascade — a falling mass, like a waterfall; depreciate — to belittle; to speak of as unimportant; vestibule — an entrance hall; accurate — conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy.
Words: ransacking: searching a place thoroughly, often roughly · cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall · depreciate: to belittle; to speak of as unimportant · vestibule: an entrance hall · accurate: conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks. A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar. Irony: Situational irony: each gift is made useless by the other's sacrifice. NarratorVoice: A chatty narrator comments directly ("a last word to the wise of these days"), turning the story into a parable. Allusion: The Magi; the Queen of Sheba and King Solomon (to compare the hair and watch to royal treasures). Watch for hair and watch: each partner's pride and identity.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1). Poverty. That is irony at work: Situational irony: each gift is made useless by the other's sacrifice.

> *ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1). Poverty. That is irony at work: Situational irony: each gift is made useless by the other's sacrifice.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The narrator calls them wise though their gifts failed, because the sacrifice expresses love. Ask: How does this line connect to sacrificial love? Expected: The gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. (The moral.)

> *of all who give gifts these two were the wisest (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The narrator calls them wise though their gifts failed, because the sacrifice expresses love.
Ask: How does this line connect to sacrificial love?
Expected answer: The gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. (The moral.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, narratorvoice (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love measured by sacrifice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Gift of the Magi develops the idea of love measured by sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. When the text says "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45), it shows this directly. Both sacrifices make the presents useless, yet Jim says "let's put our Christmas presents away," and the narrator concludes "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest."
Task: Annotate the story for irony, narratorvoice (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love measured by sacrifice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Gift of the Magi develops the idea of love measured by sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. When the text says "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45), it shows this directly. Both sacrifices make the presents useless, yet Jim says "let's put our Christmas presents away," and the narrator concludes "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special? Ask: is the ending sad or happy? Defend with evidence.
Anchor question: What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?
Facilitation: Ask: is the ending sad or happy? Defend with evidence.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love measured by sacrifice? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. ("of all who give gifts these two were the wisest", The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love measured by sacrifice? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. ("of all who give gifts these two were the wisest", The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how irony shapes love measured by sacrifice. Key takeaway: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Situational irony: each gift is made useless by the other's sacrifice.
- **NarratorVoice:** A chatty narrator comments directly ("a last word to the wise of these days"), turning the story into a parable.
- **Allusion:** The Magi; the Queen of Sheba and King Solomon (to compare the hair and watch to royal treasures).

Themes and how they develop

- **sacrificial love:** the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless.

Symbols and motifs

- **hair and watch:** each partner's pride and identity.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1) Poverty.
- “let’s put our Christmas presents away and keep’em a while” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 44) Jim's gentle response.
- “of all who give gifts these two were the wisest” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45) The moral.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift.
Evidence: “of all who give gifts these two were the wisest” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45)
Reasoning: Both sacrifices make the presents useless, yet Jim says "let’s put our Christmas presents away," and the narrator concludes "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
ransacking (verb)	searching a place thoroughly, often roughly	*She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

cascade (noun)	a falling mass, like a waterfall	*So now Della's beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
depreciate (verb)	to belittle; to speak of as unimportant	*Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vestibule (noun)	an entrance hall	*In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
accurate (adjective)	conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy	*A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
valuable (adjective)	useful; worth having	*The magi brought valuable gifts, but that was not among them.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mendicancy (noun)	the practice or state of begging	*It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
inconsequential (adjective)	not important	*For ten seconds let us regard with discreet scrutiny some inconsequential object in the other direction.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
meretricious (adjective)	showy but cheap or without real value	*It was a platinum fob chain simple and chaste in design, properly proclaiming its value by substance alone and not by meretricious ornamentation—as all good things should do.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
adornments (noun)	things that decorate or beautify	*And now, they were hers, but the tresses that should have adorned the coveted adornments were gone.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with sacrificial love?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22,

23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How much money does Della have at the start? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: One dollar and eighty-seven cents
2. What does Della sell? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Her hair
3. What does Della buy for Jim? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A platinum fob chain for his watch
4. What has Jim bought for Della? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A set of tortoise-shell combs
5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: They gave the wisest gifts, out of love
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Gift of the Magi” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her hair. The narrator calls the two foolish children but declares them the wisest of givers: they are the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Gift of the Magi”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Gift of the Magi” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.” What does “ransacking” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: ransacking: searching a place thoroughly, often roughly.
10. Reread: “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.” What does “cascade” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Gift of the Magi” suggest about love measured by sacrifice? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas. **Answer guidance:** A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all” (The Gift of the Magi,

paragraph 1): Poverty. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Gift of the Magi”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Gift of the Magi” set up that the rest of The Gift of the Magi will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “let’s put our Christmas presents away and keep’em a while” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 44): Jim's gentle response. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “of all who give gifts these two were the wisest” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45): The moral. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with sacrificial love? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1): Poverty. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “let’s put our Christmas presents away and keep’em a while” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 44): Jim's gentle response. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless.

Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45): The moral. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1): Poverty. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Gift of the Magi" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "let's put our Christmas presents away and keep'em a while" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 44): Jim's gentle response. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Gift of the Magi": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "of all who give gifts these two were the wisest" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45): The moral. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to wealth and poverty: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all" (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1): Poverty. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: "let's put our Christmas presents away and keep'em a while" (The Gift of the

Magi, paragraph 44): Jim's gentle response. On irony: Situational irony: each gift is made useless by the other's sacrifice. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Gift of the Magi” treats love measured by sacrifice with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Gift of the Magi see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “of all who give gifts these two were the wisest” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45): The moral. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve sacrificial love? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “ONE dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 1): Poverty. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “let’s put our Christmas presents away and keep’em a while” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 44): Jim's gentle response. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The irony of the gifts shows that love, not objects, is the real gift. Useful evidence: “of all who give gifts these two were the wisest” (The Gift of the Magi, paragraph 45): The moral. Theme link: the gifts are worthless; the sacrifice is priceless. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz

1. How much money does Della have at the start?
   A. Eight dollars
   B. Nothing

C. One dollar and eighty-seven cents

D. Twenty dollars

2. What does Della sell?

A. Her coat

B. Her watch

C. Her ring

D. Her hair

3. What does Della buy for Jim?

A. A gold ring

B. A new coat

C. A pair of gloves

D. A platinum fob chain for his watch

4. What has Jim bought for Della?

A. A mirror

B. A hat

C. A necklace

D. A set of tortoise-shell combs

5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'?

A. They are kings

B. They are rich

C. They gave the wisest gifts, out of love

D. They are from the East

6. In the line “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”, what does “ransacking” most nearly mean?

A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly

B. an entrance hall

C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

7. In the line “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?

A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly

B. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

C. an entrance hall

D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

Answer key: 1. C (One dollar and eighty-seven cents); 2. D (Her hair); 3. D (A platinum fob chain for his watch); 4. D (A set of tortoise-shell combs); 5. C (They gave the wisest gifts, out of love); 6. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Gift of the Magi," how does Henry show love measured by sacrifice? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): In The Gift of the Magi, how does Henry develop the idea of love measured by sacrifice? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Gift of the Magi develops the idea of love measured by sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of love measured by sacrifice. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Gift of the Magi suggests about love measured by sacrifice. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Gift of the Magi to complicate the reader's understanding of love measured by sacrifice. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Gift of the Magi within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of love measured by sacrifice responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Gift of the Magi alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of love measured by sacrifice follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Gift of the Magi and its treatment of love measured by sacrifice. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Gift of the Magi as evidence for a larger claim about love measured by sacrifice in The Gift of the Magi. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Gift of the Magi as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of love measured by sacrifice. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Gift of the Magi.

SAT-style questions

1. *Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "depreciate" most nearly mean?

   A. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

   B. showy but cheap or without real value

   C. not important

   D. things that decorate or beautify

2. *While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at $8 per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "The Gift of the Magi"?

   A. Love measured by sacrifice

   B. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

   C. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

   D. Science that poisons love

SAT key: 1. A (to belittle; to speak of as unimportant); 2. A (Love measured by sacrifice)

Whole-book test

The Gift of the Magi: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How much money does Della have at the start?
   A. Eight dollars
   B. Nothing
   C. One dollar and eighty-seven cents
   D. Twenty dollars
2. What does Della sell?
   A. Her coat
   B. Her watch
   C. Her ring
   D. Her hair
3. What does Della buy for Jim?
   A. A gold ring
   B. A new coat
   C. A pair of gloves
   D. A platinum fob chain for his watch
4. What has Jim bought for Della?
   A. A mirror
   B. A hat
   C. A necklace
   D. A set of tortoise-shell combs
5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'?
   A. They are kings
   B. They are rich
   C. They gave the wisest gifts, out of love
   D. They are from the East
6. In the line “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”, what does “ransacking” most nearly mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. an entrance hall
   C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

7. In the line “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
   C. an entrance hall
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
8. As used in the story (“She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”), what does “ransacking” mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
   C. not important
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
9. As used in the story (“So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”), what does “cascade” mean?
   A. useful; worth having
   B. a falling mass, like a waterfall
   C. showy but cheap or without real value
   D. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
10. As used in the story (“Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depr”), what does “depreciate” mean?
    A. the practice or state of begging
    B. things that decorate or beautify
    C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
    D. an entrance hall
11. As used in the story (“In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring.”), what does “vestibule” mean?
    A. not important
    B. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
    C. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
    D. an entrance hall
12. As used in the story (“A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conc”), what does “accurate” mean?
    A. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
    B. showy but cheap or without real value
    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall
    D. useful; worth having

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how sacrificial love develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how wealth and poverty develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how irony of giving develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (sacrificial love, wealth and poverty, irony of giving) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (One dollar and eighty-seven cents); 2. D (Her hair); 3. D (A platinum fob chain for his watch); 4. D (A set of tortoise-shell combs); 5. C (They gave the wisest gifts, out of love); 6. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 8. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 9. B (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 10. C (to belittle; to speak of as unimportant); 11. D (an entrance hall); 12. A (conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy)

Essay assignments

Essay: Sacrificial love

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about sacrificial love. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops sacrificial love across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of sacrificial love. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of sacrificial love, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of sacrificial love in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Wealth and poverty

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about wealth and poverty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops wealth and poverty across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of wealth and poverty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of wealth and poverty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of wealth and poverty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical method, apply it closely,

and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Irony of giving

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about irony of giving. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops irony of giving across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of irony of giving. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of irony of giving, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of irony of giving in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.